BOTANORA

N° 03



The Night Ritual

Caffeine-free tisanes to slow down and sleep better

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The Night Ritual

Caffeine-free tisanes to slow down and sleep better

This guide is about the last hour of the day. It brings together the most studied relaxing herbs, what the science really says about each, the cautions they need a 45-minute ritual, 24 recipes and a seven-night plan that help the body understand it is time to slow down.

No tisane replaces treatment for insomnia. But a repeated, warm, screen-free ritual is one of the simplest and most effective tools there is.



01

Cut caffeine early

The effect lasts hours. The chapter I table shows the cut-off time.

02

Choose your herbs

Profiles with the evidence, taste and cautions for each plant.

03

Repeat the ritual

The body learns by repetition. Give it two weeks.

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CHAPTER I

Why a ritual

The body likes warnings

Sleep does not switch on like a light. It arrives when body temperature drops, light dims and the mind gets repeated signals that the day is over. A warm drink made the same way every night is one of those signals.

01 Caffeine and timing

02 Sleep hygiene



CHAPTER I

Caffeine and timing

Caffeine takes on average five hours to drop by half in the body, and that varies a lot from person to person.

A black tea at 5 pm still has some caffeine circulating at 10 pm. For many people that does not stop sleep, but it can make it lighter and more fragmented. The rule of thumb: stop caffeine **six to eight hours before bed**, and earlier if you are sensitive.

DRINK (200 ML)	APPROX. CAFFEINE	SUGGESTED LAST TIME*
Drip coffee	80–120 mg	14h
Matcha	40–70 mg	14h
Black tea	40–70 mg	15h
Mate (gourd)	30–80 mg per round	15h
Green tea · oolong	20–50 mg	16h
White tea	15–35 mg	16h
Hojicha	10–20 mg	17h
Tisanes (chamomile, rooibos...)	none	any time

*For someone going to bed at 10 or 11 pm. Average values; they depend on the leaf, dose and steep time.

BOTANORA TIP

Green tea at night? Choose hojicha or a very light, short green. Or switch completely: rooibos gives the same "real tea" feeling with no caffeine.

A DETAIL THAT MATTERS

Drinking a lot close to bedtime can wake you up to use the bathroom. That is why the ritual uses a small 150 to 200 ml cup, taken 30 to 45 minutes before bed.

CHAPTER I

Sleep hygiene

Tea works best when the rest of the evening cooperates. Ten habits with good scientific backing.

1. **Regular schedule**, weekends included: the habit with the biggest effect.
2. **Daylight in the morning**, ideally outdoors, to set your body clock.
3. **Low, warm light** in the last hour; avoid bright white light.
4. **Screens away** 30 to 60 minutes before bed; the issue is the stimulation as much as the light.
5. **A cool, dark, quiet bedroom.**
6. **Alcohol does not help**: it makes you drowsy at first but fragments the second half of the night.
7. **A light dinner**, at least two hours before bed.
8. **Exercise** helps, but intense workouts close to bedtime can get in the way.
9. **Bed is for sleeping.** If not asleep after about 20 minutes, get up and do something calm in dim light.
10. **Write down worries** on paper before the ritual; getting them out of your head helps you switch off.

> SEEK HELP
> Insomnia lasting more than three months, loud snoring with breathing pauses or strong daytime sleepiness deserve medical evaluation. Tea does not treat these conditions.

CHAPTER II

The herbs

Six plants for the night

Chamomile, lemon balm, passionflower, linden, lavender and rooibos. Each profile gives the taste, how to brew it, what research suggests and the most important caution. Use them to build your own blends.

01 Herb profiles

02 What the science says

03 Safety and interactions



CHAPTER II

Herb profiles

Chamomile

Matricaria chamomilla

Floral, honey and apple. The most traditional night-time herb in the West.

BREW	2 tbsp flowers, 95 °C, 5 to 6 min, covered
EVIDENCE	Early: small studies with improved subjective sleep
CAUTION	Allergy if sensitive to daisies and ragweed; possible interaction with anticoagulants

Lemon balm

Melissa officinalis

Soft lemon and mint. In Brazil also called erva-cidreira, a name shared with other plants.

BREW	1 to 2 tbsp dried or a fresh handful, 6 min, covered
EVIDENCE	Early to moderate for calm and light sleep, often in combination
CAUTION	People with hypothyroidism should talk to their doctor

Passionflower

Passiflora incarnata

Herbal and slightly bitter. The studied species is incarnata, not the common sour passion fruit.

BREW	1 tsp dried herb, boiling water, 7 to 10 min
EVIDENCE	Early: a small trial with tea showed better sleep quality
CAUTION	Avoid in pregnancy; do not combine with sedatives or alcohol

Linden

Tilia spp.

Tree blossom with soft honey. A European evening tradition.

BREW	1 tbsp flowers with bracts, 95 °C, 6 to 8 min
EVIDENCE	Traditional; few human studies
CAUTION	Moderate use; people with heart conditions should check with a doctor before frequent use

Lavender

Lavandula angustifolia

Intensely floral. In the cup it works like a spice: a pinch is enough.

BREW	¼ tsp with another base, 5 min
EVIDENCE	The aroma has relaxation studies; the tea itself is little studied
CAUTION	Use only untreated culinary lavender; too much turns bitter

Rooibos

Aspalathus linearis

Caffeine-free, sweet and woody. The perfect base if you miss "real tea" at night.

BREW	1 tbsp, boiling water, 5 to 8 min
EVIDENCE	Not a sedative; it helps by replacing caffeinated drinks
CAUTION	Very well tolerated

Confusing names

COMMON NAME	PLANT	NOTE
Erva-cidreira	Melissa officinalis or Lippia alba	Two different plants with the same name in Brazil
Capim-cidreira, capim-santo	Cymbopogon citratus	Lemongrass; long leaves, citrusy
Passion fruit	Passiflora edulis	Not the species studied for sleep (P. incarnata)
Roman chamomile	Chamaemelum nobile	More bitter than common chamomile

WHEN BUYING

Buy herbs with the scientific name on the label. It is the only guarantee that you are getting the right plant.

CHAPTER II

What the science says

An honest summary. "Early" means promising, not proven.

HERB	EVIDENCE LEVEL	WHAT WAS OBSERVED
Chamomile	Early	Modest improvement in subjective sleep quality in some groups, such as older adults and postpartum women; little effect on total sleep time.
Lemon balm	Early to moderate	Less restlessness and better light sleep, often studied together with valerian.
Passionflower	Early	A small trial with daily tea showed better perceived sleep quality.
Lavender	Moderate for aroma	Aromatherapy and standardised capsules have studies for anxiety; tea is little studied.
Linden	Traditional	Wide historical use; human trials are lacking.
Rooibos	Indirect	The benefit comes from replacing caffeinated drinks.

So does it work?

Night-time herbs have gentle effects. Studies suggest they help you relax and feel your sleep is more restful, not that they knock anyone out. Much of the benefit comes from the whole package: a warm drink, low light, a pause and repetition.

That is not nothing. Consistent rituals are among the most recommended strategies for mild insomnia, and a cup of chamomile is a pleasant and safe way to build one.

The herb helps. The ritual teaches. Repetition makes it stick.

CHAPTER II

Safety and interactions

Herbs are active: that is why they work, and why they need care.

SITUATION	AVOID OR CONSULT	WHY
Pregnancy and breastfeeding	Passionflower, valerian, daily use of other medicinal herbs	Safety not established
Taking sedatives, anxiolytics or antidepressants	Passionflower, valerian, strong combinations	Additive effect, excessive drowsiness
Anticoagulants (e.g. warfarin)	Large amounts of chamomile	A possible interaction has been described
Hypothyroidism	Daily lemon balm	Possible effect on the thyroid
Allergy to daisies or ragweed	Chamomile	Same plant family (Asteraceae)
Young children	Herbs in general without guidance; honey under 1 year	Different doses and safety
Scheduled surgery	Sedative herbs in the two weeks before	Interaction with anaesthesia

Good practice

- Start with one herb at a time for a few days to learn how you react.
- Choose herbs from known sources, dry, mould-free and labelled with their scientific name.
- Do not drive or operate machinery if you feel drowsy.
- If you take regular medication, show your list of herbs to your doctor or pharmacist.

ABOUT VALERIAN

Valerian appears in many "sleep" blends. It has mixed evidence, a strong smell and interacts with sedatives and alcohol. We did not include it in this guide's blends.

CHAPTER III

The protocol

Forty-five minutes

A short routine, always the same. In the first week it feels formal; in the second, the body starts anticipating sleep as soon as the kettle warms up.

01 The 45-minute ritual

02 Brewing well



CHAPTER III

The 45-minute ritual

WHEN	WHAT TO DO	WHY
−45 min	Dim the lights at home. Heat the water. Take out your usual cup.	Low light signals night to the body clock
−40 min	Put together the blend and steep it covered. Use the time to jot down tomorrow's to-dos.	Getting worries out of your head
−35 min	Phone in another room, on silent.	Less stimulation and blue light
−30 min	Drink slowly, seated, no screens. Read something light on paper or just stay with the cup.	The pause is part of the effect
−15 min	Wash up, nightclothes, a cool dark room.	A drop in temperature helps you fall asleep
−5 min	In bed: 4-7-8 breathing or gentle stretching.	Slows breathing and heart rate

4-7-8 breathing

1. Breathe in through the nose for a count of 4.
2. Hold for a count of 7.
3. Breathe out slowly through the mouth for a count of 8.
4. Repeat four times. If you feel dizzy, shorten the counts.

> **BOTANORA TIP**
> Do the ritual even on nights when you are already sleepy. Repetition is what trains the body, not the need of the day.

CHAPTER III

Brewing well

Tisanes are simpler than tea, but three details change everything.

Always cover

Flower oils evaporate with the steam. Covering the cup is what separates a fragrant chamomile from warm water.

Use more herb

Dried flowers are light and bulky. Two tablespoons per 250 ml is the measure, not one teaspoon.

Right water

Flowers: 90 to 95 °C. Rooibos, seeds and roots: boiling. Much hotter makes lavender and lemon balm bitter.

Bag or whole flower?

Bags are convenient, but the herb comes crushed and loses aroma faster. Whole flowers give a sweeter, more fragrant cup. If you use bags, use two per cup and cover.

To sweeten or not

A teaspoon of honey, added once the drink is warm, rounds off the more bitter herbs. Avoid too much sugar at night: many tisanes in this guide are naturally sweet.

HERB	AMOUNT / 250 ML	TEMPERATURE	TIME
Chamomile	2 tbsp	95 °C	5–6 min
Lemon balm	1–2 tbsp	90–95 °C	6 min
Passionflower	1 tsp	100 °C	7–10 min
Linden	1 tbsp	95 °C	6–8 min
Lavender	¼ tsp	90 °C	5 min
Rooibos	1 tbsp	100 °C	5–8 min

CHAPTER IV

Twenty blends

For every night

Tested combinations for 250 ml of water, caffeine-free. Start with the classics and, after two weeks, invent your own. Spoon measures: tsp ≈ 5 ml, tbsp ≈ 15 ml.



N° 01

Classic Chamomile

Honey, hay, apple.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

2 tbsp	chamomile flowers

Steep 5 to 6 min, covered.

N° 02

Chamomile & Lemon Balm

Floral and lightly citrusy.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	chamomile
1 tbsp	dried lemon balm

Steep 6 min, covered.

N° 03

Moon Rooibos

Sweet, woody, vanilla.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	rooibos
1 tsp	chamomile

Boiling water; 6 min. Rooibos will not turn bitter.

N° 04

Serene Linden

Soft honey and tree blossom.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	linden flowers
1 tsp	lemon balm

Steep 6 to 8 min, covered.

N° 05

Quiet Lavender

Fresh floral, without the soap.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1½ tbsp	chamomile
¼ tsp	culinary lavender

5 min, covered. Too much lavender turns bitter and cosmetic: start small.

N° 06

Passionflower & Rooibos

Herbal, rounded.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tsp	dried passionflower (P. incarnata)
1 tbsp	rooibos

Boiling water; 7 min.

N° 07

Backyard Lemon Balm

Green lemon and soft mint.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 handful	fresh lemon balm
1 slice	lime (optional)

Bruise the leaves lightly; 6 min, covered.

N° 08

Gentle Lemon Verbena

Fragrant lemon and chamomile, very light.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	dried lemon verbena (Aloysia citrodora)
1 tsp	chamomile

Water at 90 °C; 5 min, covered.

N° 09

Lettuce & Mint

Grandma's lettuce tea, made tastier.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

3 leaves	washed romaine or leaf lettuce
4 leaves	mint

Simmer the lettuce 5 min in 250 ml, turn off, add the mint: 3 min.

N° 10

Night Fennel

Natural sweetness, liquorice, after-dinner.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tsp	fennel seeds
1 tbsp	chamomile

Crush the seeds; 6 min, covered.

N° 11

Light Golden Milk

Turmeric, cinnamon and warm milk.

1 MUG · WITH MILK

200 ml	milk or plant milk
½ tsp	turmeric
1 pinch	cinnamon and black pepper

Heat without boiling, stirring; sweeten with honey once warm.

N° 12

Mint & Lemon Balm

Fresh for warm nights.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tsp	dried mint
1 tbsp	lemon balm

5 min, covered. Great warm or at room temperature.

N° 13

Rose & Chamomile

Delicate and fragrant.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1½ tbsp	chamomile
1 tsp	culinary rose petals

5 min, covered.

N° 14

Rooibos & Orange

Sweet winter citrus.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	rooibos
1 strip	orange peel
1	clove (optional)

Boiling water; 6 min.

N° 15

Linden & Apple

Tree blossom and stewed fruit.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	linden
¼	apple, diced

Simmer the apple 4 min; turn off and steep the linden 6 min.

N° 16

Brazilian Lemon Verbena

Herbal citrus from Lippia alba.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 handful	fresh Lippia alba leaves

6 min, covered. Very common in southern and south-eastern Brazilian gardens.

N° 17

Orange Blossom & Chamomile

Floral, delicate, almost a perfume.

1 MUG · WITH MILK

1 tsp	dried orange blossoms
1 tbsp	chamomile

Water at 90 °C; 5 min, covered.

N° 18

Cocoa & Rooibos

A light dessert.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	rooibos
1 tsp	cacao nibs or husks

Boiling water; 6 min. Cacao husk has very little caffeine.

N° 19

Gentle Ginger

Quiet warmth for cold nights.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

2 slices	ginger
1 tbsp	chamomile

Simmer the ginger 3 min; turn off, add chamomile: 5 min.

N° 20

The Whole Night

The house blend: floral, citrus and sweet.

250 ML · CAFFEINE-FREE

1 tbsp	chamomile
1 tsp	lemon balm
1 tsp	rooibos
1 pinch	lavender

Water at 95 °C; 6 min, covered.

Create your own

Choose a base (chamomile, rooibos or linden), a supporting voice (lemon balm, lemongrass, apple) and, if you like, an accent (lavender, rose, cinnamon). Keep the base at least half of the mix and change one thing at a time.

21 Oat Milk with Date and Cinnamon

Creamy and sweetened only with fruit.

Hot · 8 min · 1 mug · 250 ml · Caffeine-free · With milk · Easy

INGREDIENTS

250 ml	oat drink
2	pitted dates
¼ tsp	cinnamon
1 pinch	salt

METHOD

1. Blend the oat drink with the dates until smooth.
2. Warm with the cinnamon and salt over low heat, without boiling.
3. Serve frothy.

BARISTA TIP The pinch of salt brings out the date's sweetness. Good if you want to avoid sugar at night.

22 Almond Milk with Vanilla and Nutmeg

Grandma's warm milk, dairy-free.

Hot · 6 min · 1 mug · 250 ml · Caffeine-free · With milk · Easy

INGREDIENTS

250 ml	almond milk
2 drops	vanilla extract
1 pinch	grated nutmeg
1 tsp	honey

METHOD

1. Warm the almond milk without boiling.
2. Add the vanilla and honey.
3. Grate the nutmeg on top at the last moment.

BARISTA TIP Just a pinch of nutmeg: in large amounts it is harmful.

23 Banana and Cinnamon Tea

Made with the whole fruit, caffeine-free.

Hot · 15 min · 2 cups · Caffeine-free · Easy

INGREDIENTS

1	ripe organic banana, peel on, well washed
500 ml	water
1	cinnamon stick

METHOD

1. Trim the ends of the banana and cut it into 3 pieces, peel on.
2. Simmer with the cinnamon over low heat for 10 min.
3. Strain and drink warm. Eat the cooked banana, if you like.

BARISTA TIP Use an organic banana: the peel goes into the water. The taste is mild and naturally sweet.

24 Warm Lemon Balm and Lemon

Light and citrusy, for after dinner.

Hot · 8 min · 2 cups · Caffeine-free · Easy

INGREDIENTS

12 leaves	fresh lemon balm (or 2 tbsp dried)
3 buds	lavender
400 ml	water at 90 °C
2 slices	lemon

METHOD

1. Bruise the lemon balm leaves lightly in your hands.
2. Steep with the lavender and lemon for 6 min, covered.
3. Strain and drink warm.

BARISTA TIP Covering is essential: the calming oils are the first to evaporate.

GETTING STARTED

Your first week

A seven-night plan to build the habit. Change one thing per night and observe.

NIGHT	WHAT TO DO	SLEPT WELL? (1 TO 5)
Night 1	Screens off 60 min before. Plain chamomile.	
Night 2	A cooler room (18 to 21 °C). Lemon balm and lemon.	
Night 3	4-7-8 breathing with the cup in your hands. A chapter IV blend.	
Night 4	A light dinner 3 h before bed. Oat milk with date and cinnamon.	
Night 5	Write three lines in the diary. Rooibos.	
Night 6	A warm bath 90 min before. Banana and cinnamon tea.	
Night 7	Repeat the night that worked best and note why.	

Shopping list for the week

Herbs

Chamomile (50 g), dried or fresh lemon balm, culinary lavender (20 g), rooibos (100 g).

Pantry

Honey, cinnamon sticks, dates, oat drink, almond milk, an organic banana, lemons.

Tea does not put you to sleep. It tells your body the day is over.

TO PRINT

Two-week diary

Keep notes for two weeks. Patterns show up fast: the 4 pm coffee, the night with screens, the blend that worked.

	LAST COFFEE / CAFFEINATED TEA	EVENING BLEND	BEDTIME	SCREENS OFF	HOW I WOKE (1 TO 5)
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					

	LAST COFFEE / CAFFEINATED TEA	EVENING BLEND	BEDTIME	SCREENS OFF	HOW I WOKE (1 TO 5)
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					



Thank you for brewing with us

The Botanora collection has ten guides, each devoted to one way of living with tea. Keep exploring:

01 Signature Infusions
02 The Tea Atlas
04 Focus & Energy
05 Iced & Cold Brew
06 Matcha at Home
07 Backyard Herbs
08 Crafting Blends
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